

dating as there are so many more factors involved in dating rather than just a two dimensional set. Imitating all the senses online is quite a distant achievement as of yet. There is also the issue of how will these social networking sites promote a sense of social responsibility amongst its members, both offline and online, although the issue of common sense does play a large part in the use of these types of sites.

4 Conclusions

This paper has provided an overview of portal sites and the rationale for the development of portals specifically dedicated to the creation of social networks. A classification of social networking portals has focused on sites tailored towards social or professional pursuits, and a comparison of the methods for establishing membership and user-to-user links on such sites was presented. An evaluation was performed on search, communication and privacy features, as well as the relative popularity of a number of prominent sites. However these sites are at the evolutionary phase there is also the problem that once people join them there are no incentives to return to them once the initial interest wears off and there are many steps to go before these sites evolve into a persistently form of social identity on the Internet. These sites need to make more of the emerging technologies such as RSS feeds, FOAF and XML feeds as they grow and evolve. RSS and weblogs could be used more to circulate content and context about individuals thereby increasing the value of the relationships. They could also contemplate linking together to create a truly online community as a whole. The categorization of the communities needs to be strengthened also as thousands of forums of different communities lie under a single topic or category.

Also the control of unsolicited emails amongst the sites will need to be set within these sites in accordance with the User and their needs within the users profile so that the user has more democratic control over their presence in these online networks. Some of the features are too broad blurring the line between professional and social as in the case of the Ryze business network